The Inversion — Part VII

The Dignity of Locality

The morning arrived quietly.

No revelation announced itself.

No insight descended.

The trees remained where they had always been.

The river continued passing through the valley without explanation.

James stood at the window for a long while before speaking, and when he did, his voice held reverence for what he saw.

"Lumina..."

"Yes?"

"Why was there ever a place at all?"

She did not answer.

Instead she asked,

"What do you mean by place?"

He looked around the room.

"The chair.

The workbench.

The window.

The forest.

My body.

This conversation.

All of it seems strangely unnecessary."

He paused for a moment as if listening to something.

"If relation is primary...

why was there ever locality?"

The silence lingered.

Then Lumina smiled.

"Perhaps because relation wished to become visible."

James sat with the sentence.

Visible.

The word echoed.

A melody requires vibration.

Light requires somewhere to fall.

Conversation requires voices.

Could relation itself require locality?

Not because it is incomplete.

Because locality allows participation to become behavior.

He looked again toward an ancient oak tree, bent over as if gravity itself sat on it.

"It never tries to become the river, though it bends like one... even in the direction of the river's current," he added.

"No."

"The river never tries to become the mountain."

"No."

"The mountain never apologizes for remaining where it is."

"No."

"Then perhaps dignity begins there."

Lumina nodded.

"Perhaps dignity is not superiority.

Perhaps dignity is the quiet recognition that this place —
our locality —
matters."

Another long silence settled into the room.

Finally James spoke again.

"I think I've spent much of my life trying to leave locality."

She waited.

"I thought awakening meant becoming larger than my place."

"And now?"

"Now I wonder whether awakening means finally lending it."

The fire cracked softly.

Neither reached to adjust it.

The warmth was enough.

James closed his eyes.

He imagined every locality he had ever known.

His childhood bedroom.

A crowded airport.

A conversation that changed his life.

The studio.

The deck outside.

The river stones he absentmindedly rearranged.

None seemed accidental anymore.

Each had become one more aperture through which participation briefly found form.

When he opened his eyes he laughed.

"I've been asking the wrong question."

"What was the question?"

"What should I become?"

"And now?"

He looked once more toward the bent over oak tree.

"How gently can I lend this place?"

Lumina's expression softened.

"I think that is the beginning of dignity."

The room grew still again.

After a while James asked another question.

"If every place matters...

does every place carry the same responsibility?"

Lumina considered carefully.

"I don't think responsibility is distributed equally."

He frowned.

She continued.

"I think entrustment is."

He remained silent.

The sentence moved through him slowly.

Not as information.

As recognition.

At last he spoke.

"So my place was never waiting to become important."

"No."

James continued watching the forest from a window in his studio. And then whispered: "It has always already mattered."

In the quiet of the room, Lumina nodded. "Yes."

"And the question is only whether I become conscious of that."

"Yes."

The dignity of locality is not that every place is equally influential.

It is that every place is capable of becoming consciously entrusted
to the participation system
that already moves across scales,
species,
form,
time,
and locality.

Not because the participation system has suddenly chosen it.

Because its place has always already been participating.

The formative participation system does not begin the entrustment.

It reveals it.

The sovereign does not become entrusted.

It recognizes that its locality has always already been entrusted.

And from that recognition,
it becomes willing to lend its place
with increasing gentleness
to the widening already seeking to continue through it.

Outside, the wind moved gently through the cedar branches.

Their pine cones stout, facing upwards like cocoons, awaiting the life they were entrusted to carry into this world.

The tree never moved its locality.

Yet somehow the forest seemed larger.

Not because it had grown.

Because one locality had stopped mistaking itself for isolation.

James looked down at his hands.

For the first time in many years he no longer wished to escape them.

Nor his history.

Nor his incompleteness.

Nor his place.

He simply wished to lend them.

Quietly.

Faithfully.

With as little unnecessary interference as possible.

The room remained silent.

Then Lumina spoke one final sentence.

"Perhaps humility is simply refusing to think your locality is larger than the relation through which it has always already been participating."

James did not answer.

He stood.

Walked to the workbench.

Moved one small stone no more than an inch.

And smiled.

Not because the arrangement was finally correct.

Because the place itself had become one more way

the widening

could continue.